LOVE MARRIAGE
By Monica Ali
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BOOKS

SEX, LIES AND FAMILY TIES

Monica Ali's new novel might leave you breathless, but its rewards are well worth the exertion

Monica Ali confessed in a recent interview that the reception of her last novel, *Untold Story*, left her paralysed for a decade with depression and a catastrophic loss of confidence. Critics, and perhaps readers, she says, were left "confused" by a writer they associated with immigrant narratives turning her hand to a counterfactual about Princess Diana. Stay in your lane, Ali assumed they were saying. That she was foolish and naive to think she could write about "whatever I wanted, like a white male writer can".

After 11 years, Monica Ali has re-emerged with her fourth novel, a familiar blockbuster. Having read about her dejection at the critical obsession with taxonomy, the desire to bully certain kinds of writers (women and minorities) and to put them in their place, you almost wish she would come back fists swinging, flipping the bird at her critics with a radical departure from what you might imagine to be the 'typical' Ali novel. But who wants to tell a writer what to write?

Of course, Ali's writerly fate was sealed the moment her debut *Brick Lane* burst onto the British literary scene. A novel about immigration, abuse, infidelity, identity, arranged marriages, hypocrisy, *Brick Lane* angered the self-appointed 'leaders' of the Bangladeshi immigrant community who accused Ali of pandering to British prejudices.

Love Marriage begins with the impending nuptials of Yasmin Ghorami, daughter of Bangladeshi immigrants, and Joe Sangster, son of a prominent English columnist and writer and beneficiary of all the certainties of upper middle class English life. "In the Ghorami household, sex was never mentioned", the novel begins. It's the cue for a comedy of manners, an unravelling of every family taboo. The novel begins by exploring Yasmin's feelings of embarrassment about her immigrant parents, how they don't look right, sound right, act right and over many hundreds of pages shows how she has misunderstood not just her own parents, but the ostensibly warm and easy relationship between Joe and his mother, Joe himself and, indeed, the strength of her own relationship with Joe.

It's a novel in part at least about the upturning of assumptions, about the folly of trying to box people in. (Maybe Ali is flipping the bird at her critics after all.) Perhaps fittingly, given Ali's love for the great 19th-century novelists, *Love Marriage* is a teeming, heavily populated, creakily plotted novel of the kind Henry James famously described—both disparagingly and admiringly—as "large, loose, baggy monsters".

There is so much going on; so many people talking, doing, feeling, thinking, being; so many skeletons tumbling out of closets; so much action and conversely inaction, that readers will find themselves breathless and occasionally impatient with yet another digression. Ali is sometimes clunky, reliant on cliches and shortcuts of both character and phrase. Still, *Love Marriage* is a likeable, large-hearted, forgiving novel. There is horror, too, but Ali is broadly optimistic about human nature. There are no second acts in American lives, Scott Fitzgerald did not say, or at least he said more. *Love Marriage* is about second acts, about the reassuring possibility that love and understanding can help us make up for, and recover from, even the most terrible mistakes. ■

–Shougat Dasgupta

Monica Ali's *Love Marriage* is about second acts, about how love can help us recover from terrible mistakes



YOLANDE DE VRIES